

Firming up a Niche Market Despite the Skeptics

Despite the gender-centric hardships of the early days, having built 7 brands in 9 years, Mamaearth's Ghazal Alagh shares how "Being a woman in leadership means people watch you more. They expect you to mess up. That's okay. Let them watch." She urges women not to shrink themselves to fit in. "Learn, persist, and keep showing up," she advises firmly.

Motherhood is the mother of invention. That's a nice twist to the old saying, because being a mom is no cakewalk. Born on her return from the Philippines to India, Ghazal's first baby, Agastya, was diagnosed with a skin condition. There was no baby product in the market at the time which did not bring out rashes and discomfort in the infant. Her growing distress planted the seed of Mamaearth in her. Galvanised by the idea of creating safe and gentle products for infants she went headlong into deep research before breaking out with a business for toxin-free baby care products. Her research also led her to identify this gap in the baby products market, fuelling her quest for creating a viable product with international standards. In 2016 Ghazal and her husband Varun launched Mamaearth with six products for babies, under the umbrella of Honasa Consumer Ltd.

Ghazal navigated the numerous hurdles of managing both motherhood and business, drowning the deafening sounds of the naysayers, with the active support of Varun's FMCG experience. Despite the gender-centric bias and resistance of some team members, and the challenges of the business itself, she stood robustly behind her commitment to offering safe, natural products for families across India.

This adversity played a pivotal role in strengthening her determination to build up a brand that would be recognised for prioritizing safety and quality for every child and parent.

Ghazal's brush with entrepreneurship was first sparked by another personal challenge. This time it was her struggle with weight loss, made worse by frequent relocations. Her start-up "Diet Expert"—was conceived to address people looking for weight loss solutions amid travel constraints. Though it took off well and even reflected good potential, the challenges it faced ultimately led to Diet Expert's closure.

The entrepreneurship spirit of Ghazal is rooted in her early days as a young intern earning a stipend of INR 5000 while she was pursuing her graduation. The lessons she came away with were the twin values of responsibility and self-sufficiency. Having secured a Bachelor of Computer Applications Degree from Punjab University she went on to get a Degree in Fine Arts from the New York Academy of Arts. In 2008, Ghazal worked as a corporate trainer at NIIT Limited for two years. During this period, she trained managers and engineers from several IT companies in SQL, J2ME, and Oracle. Diet Expert was her first venture when she moved to the Philippines with husband Varun.

For Alagh, her visionary outlook for Mamaearth, has travelled way beyond the bounds of just 'business'. The bigger picture embraces the objective of creating a positive impact on individuals' lives and the environment with safe and sustain-



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—Ghazal Alagh
Co-Founder Mamaearth

able products for the well-being of people and the planet.

Ghazal Alagh co-founded Honasa Consumer, Mamaearth's parent firm. This stemmed from Mamaearth's diversification from baby care to personal care, expanding from six to 140 products. Honasa picked up three firms and subsequently went about building its own brands. The Company is now worth over INR 10,000 Cr., making it also Asia's first MADE SAFE-certified brand.

Shaped by concentrated digital-first market strategy, ably supported by a strong pull of customers through social media platforms, Mamaearth ranks amongst India's fastest-growing FMCG.